

THREE RIVERS

GO DARK

A Pittsburgh Zombie Response & Recovery Tabletop Exercise

STUDENT EXERCISE BOOK
DO NOT OPEN IN THE TUNNELS

Operational Period: 30 April–1 May, 20XX

Your mission: turn scattered skills and credentials into one functioning emergency organization.

Exercise rules

This is fiction. You are solving a classroom emergency. Do not self-deploy, contact 911, transmit on restricted radio frequencies, fly a drone, or enter a dangerous location because of this exercise.

How the tabletop works

1. Read only the information your instructor releases.
2. Stay in your assigned role. Give advice within your capability.
3. Route decisions through the incident organization.
4. Write down important messages, resources, locations, and assumptions.
5. Expect incomplete and contradictory information.
6. When a new inject arrives, update the plan—do not pretend the old plan still works.

Success conditions

- Protect life without creating new victims.
- Maintain accountability for teams and resources.
- Build a common operating picture.
- Communicate verified information.
- Support survivors through stabilization and early recovery.
- Explain why your team accepted some risks and rejected others.

Remember: Pittsburgh is dark. The rivers carry wreckage. Something keeps striking the doors below street level. The dead are frightening; confusion is more dangerous.

Threat briefing: Hemlock Fever

State	Observed behavior	Operational implication
Susceptible	Uninfected survivor; may be injured, panicked, or separated.	Protect, account for, shelter, communicate.
Undead	Recently infected; fever, gray skin, confusion, violent spasms. Conversion may be delayed.	Do not diagnose by rumor. Isolate from the general shelter and request qualified medical direction.
Zombie	Reanimated, attracted to noise and movement, persistent but poor at complex barriers.	Avoid contact. Report location and movement. Students do not engage.
Dead	No movement. Cause and infection status may be unknown.	Treat as a biohazard and evidence scene. Do not move without direction.

Exercise convention: a bite or blood exposure is a medical emergency, not permission to harm or abandon a person.

Situation: 30 April, 07:00

Three nights ago, emergency departments reported patients with extreme fever, loss of speech, and violent convulsions. By midnight, 911 calls overwhelmed the system. Before sunrise, electrical failures rolled through the city.

The Fort Pitt and Liberty tunnels are closed. Abandoned vehicles jam the Parkway East. A dark column of smoke rises beyond the Strip District. The Monongahela carries furniture, trash, and one empty ambulance with its rear doors open. From somewhere under downtown comes the metallic groan of a train that should not be moving.

Your school has become **Three Rivers Coordination Site**, a supervised neighborhood support point outside the immediate hot zone. Adult public-safety agencies remain in authority, but communications are intermittent. Your student cohort is assigned safe support functions: information, mapping, logistics, documentation, weather observation, shelter support, and supervised technical tasks.

Verified at 07:00

- 62 survivors are at the site; 11 are children under ten.
- Two adults have non-life-threatening injuries. One is feverish and has blood on a sleeve; the source is unknown.
- Commercial power is out. Generator fuel is estimated at six hours.
- Cellular service is unreliable. A local amateur-radio repeater is operating.
- Heavy rain is forecast. Storm drains are clogged with debris.
- A message reports six residents stranded on the upper floor of a senior building near the Monongahela.
- No student team may enter a hot zone or leave without instructor authorization.

Exercise objectives

1. Establish an ICS organization and three incident objectives.
2. Verify and map survivor, hazard, and resource information.
3. Create a communications and public-information plan.
4. Support a supervised search or reconnaissance plan without exceeding credentials.
5. Operate shelter, feeding, supply, and worker-safety systems.
6. Plan the transition from response to recovery by May 1.

Pittsburgh operating sectors

This is a schematic exercise map, not a navigation map.

Sector	Exercise area	Known condition
ALPHA	North Shore / Allegheny River	Stadium lots contain stranded vehicles; radio reports are unverified.
BRAVO	Downtown / Point	Power out; streets blocked; movement reported beneath street level.
CHARLIE	Strip District / Lawrenceville edge	Warehouse fire and drifting smoke; possible food and medical supplies.
DELTA	Oakland / hospital district	Hospitals operating under emergency plans; access controlled.
ECHO	South Side / Monongahela corridor	Low streets flooding; senior-building report remains open.
FOXTROT	Hill neighborhoods / coordination site	Current shelter and command location; limited fuel and sanitation.

Initial incident organization

Function	Questions it must answer
Incident Command	What are the priorities and objectives? Who has authority? What risks are acceptable?
Safety	What can hurt responders or survivors? What controls and stop-work rules are needed?
Public Information / Liaison	What is verified? What can be released? Which partner has authority or capability?
Operations	What work must happen now? Who is qualified and supervised to do it?

Planning	What is happening, where, and next? What is the common operating picture?
Logistics	What people, supplies, food, communications, facilities, and transport are needed?
Finance/Admin	What time, cost, damage, donation, and accountability records must be preserved?

Our three incident objectives

#	Specific objective	Owner	Completion measure
1			
2			
3			

Decision worksheet

Decision	Team response
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What do we know?

What is only reported or assumed?

What is the immediate life-safety problem?

What are our options?

Which option do we select, and why?

Who has authority and capability?

What could go wrong?

What must be communicated and recorded?

Incident status board

Time	Location	Verified situation	Assigned action / team	Status
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Resource requests

Time	Resource and quantity	Needed where/when	Purpose	Approved/ status
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Message form

To:

From:

Time:

Priority:

Emergency / Priority / Routine

Message:

Action/reply:

Logged by: Closed:

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Shelter and recovery status

Category	Current count/status	Need	Action owner
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- Survivors/ accountability
- Medical/isolation
- Water/food/allergens
- Sanitation/waste
- Power/fuel
- Communications
- Weather/flooding
- Transport/reunification

After-action notes

What worked?

What failed or nearly failed?

What credential or skill mattered?

What should happen before May
1?

IF THE RADIO WHISPERS YOUR NAME, LOG THE MESSAGE—DO NOT ANSWER ALONE.